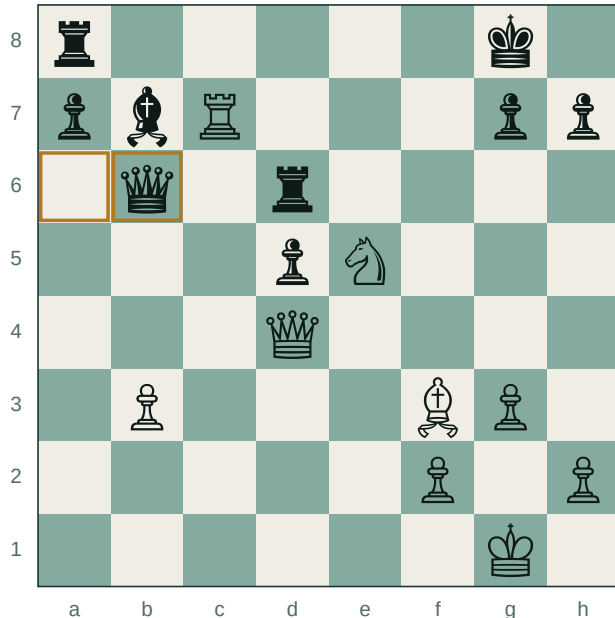


Capture the defender: White, move 26

Capture the defender

White to move



Previous move: 25...Qb6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

26. Qxb6 Rxb6 27. Rxb7 Rxb7 28. Bxd5+ Kf8 29. Bxb7

26.Qxb6 The queen captures the queen on b6. From b6 it attacks rook on d6 and bishop on b7. Recorded reply: **26...Rxb6**.

27.Rxb7 The rook captures the bishop on b7. Recorded reply: **27...Rxb7**.

28.Bxd5+ Check restricts Black to 3 legal replies here. From d5 it attacks king on g8 and rook on b7. Recorded reply: **28...Kf8**.

29.Bxb7 The bishop captures the rook on b7.

At the end, nominal material is White 10 / Black 8 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +4. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +4:** the balance goes from -2 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g8. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.